

Pioneer Life

Some Things that Happened in Paulding County Many Years Ago

Geary, Okla, Nov 21, 1906

To the Editor of Reflector.

Dear Sir: As I have just heard of the death of my mother at Bedford, O. And I am feeling so sadly about her and am so far away as not to be at her bed side in her last hours, and always realizing that in her I had a true and noble mother, not only in name but in deed, and many of the old settlers will never forget **Mrs Catherine Clase** formerly Aunt **Catherine Ryel** as she was known better by that name than any other and while she has gone from earth never to return I can't help but think of the hardships dear old mother has passed through and to bring back some of the hard times to memory that we had in the settlement of Paulding county, O., so that our young folks can realize a little of her past life. Her maiden name was **Yunker**, her father moving from Penn. To Portage Co, Ohio when she was a little girl. She was married to **John A. Ryel** when 16 years old. Father was a blacksmith by trade and worked at his trade for several years at Shalersville, Portage Co, O., then at Cleveland, O. Finally thinking he would like to own a little home took a horse and wagon and drove to Defiance, O., and there traded it for the eighty now owned by **James Drew** but by some mistake settled in the big woods a few rods southeast of **Web Coomer's** barn formerly owned by **James Bainbridge**. That was in 1852 I think. We had no roads only that which Anthony Wayne had cut along from junction of Wabash and Erie canal up Flat Rock creek and we had no near neighbors. **Arthur Chinworth**, old man **Shelly**, **Wilson Graham**, old man **Radenbaugh**, **James Shepard**, **Arch Chaney**, **John Fisher**, **Isaac Snyder**, **Jonathan Daniels**, **Jacob Henry**, **Henry** (), and **David Malott**, were our closest neighbors and they were good neighbors too, as they many times divided the last half bushel of corn meal with father for a little blacksmithing that he took home and returned to them carrying coal from Antwerp on his back through the woods.

No roads for many years while I the oldest with three or four more little ragged hungry fellows stayed with that old mother that took fathers ax and cut brush, deadened the trees and all worked hard all day.

We helped to dig the first ditch along the Antwerp road from Payne to Antwerp several years after we came here.

I well remember the first pair of shoes I had. Some of our folks sent us a barrel of goods from Portage county. Father and mother took a hand sled and started in the morning for Antwerp through the woods and as they were sent for Christmas the woods was full of water, the ice thin and late at night they got home and mother's feet and limbs were terribly frozen. It layed her up for a long time. In the barrel was some large apples, some clothes (old ones) a pair of old shoes that fit me and I took good care of them too.

Job Pugh got a little set of burrs to grind corn and well I remember when father, mother, and I shelled a bushel and a half of corn, carried it through the woods for four miles and ground it by

turning a lever walking around, pulling and pushing til night then **Mr Pugh** would toll it and we all carried it home. It cost **Mr Pugh** a big thing then.

Mother played the violin for many dances at Paulding, Defiance, Fort Wayne, Decatur and all over the county and that saved us from having to leave our home. Times were hard but father seemed to think if I keep this land I always will own a home, and he did as long as he lived. He died some twenty ago. He told many a farmer what Paulding county would be some day, but we didn't see it that way. **Eli Gaut, Henry Radenbaugh, Moses Pugh, Wilson Graham** and a few others will recollect all I have said and more.

Mother, father, **Wilson and Mary Graham, Sol Chinworth**, myself, **Jacob Barber [Barbier], Henry Shelly, Abe Hooker** and a few others cut the logs hauled them and built the first schoolhouse at the corner of **Sol Chinworth's** place. The old mothers that have passed away, mine being the last among many, all did as much toward the early improvements of Paulding county as the men. They used the ax, rolled the logs and helped burn them that Paulding county might be what it is today.

Father paid a large price for his land in trade, \$2.50 per acre. Some was selling at 37 ½ cents per acre. The younger generation of Payne and vicinity can now see by looking back fifty or sixty years what they ought to see ahead, that is get you a cheap home in a new country and grow up with it as we did. Don't think but it was a hard task for that mother to leave eastern Ohio seemingly going as far west then as Oklahoma is now and not see father and mother for many years but by so doing they had them a home as father said and today many of the folks of Paulding county should come to Okla, or Texas where you can own a 160 acres of rich land that will cost from \$5 to \$25 an acre and in many instances will pay for itself in one and two years and in a few years will sell for 75 and 80 dollars an acre. Lots of land around Oklahoma City is selling at \$100 an acre. Fourteen years ago it was selling for \$16 per 160 acres.

Don't say that chances are all gone. Not so. Plenty of chances yet. Here farms close to Geary seven years ago sold for ten, and as low as seven dollars and acre. Now they are selling at seven and eight thousand for the 160. A little farther back from the city 2000, 3000, 5000, and so on soon will be 75 to 100 dolloars an acre. Some cheaper. Remember you are not going through what those old mothers did in Ohio in making a home in prairie country.

Yours Truly,
Charles Ryel

Source: Ray Keck found this in the *Payne Reflector*, 1906, while researching information about the GAR.

Editor's Note: People wrote and spoke a little differently than we do now. Charles Ryel's letter was transcribed without changing grammar or wording. I'm not sure I agree with his sales pitch in the last paragraph. I am happy that my family stayed in this area.